scared, even—of what I would face. I was very worried about what I would say, or how they would react, especially since none of us were recognizable leaders. And so I took comfort in the knowledge that I would be lost in a sea of fellow yatris. And the first few days I just focused on the act of walking, gazing at India's wondrous landscapes. But the manner in which people responded just melted all my fears and anxieties. People could be reductive and say that Indians are simple and emotional, and maybe we are. But the honest truth is that those thousands of people waving, smiling and running alongside us in village after village changed something in me. What were faceless crowds suddenly became individuals with curious and friendly smiles. I no longer needed a prop or a shield. And when I started looking deep into their eyes, I automatically began connecting with them. Their eyes would widen with joy and anticipation, and they would enthusiastically beckon to us. They would make their children play with us, and we were inundated with requests for selfies and group photos. Wizened and weathered old grandmothers would gently bless us while girls would giggle uncontrollably when we waved at them. Children would breathlessly trot along with us for as long as they could (or until their mothers let them), sharing their biscuits and animatedly telling us their innocent stories. Even cold and aloof people would invariably soften if we reached out to shake their hands. They would initially hesitate and try to avoid us, but something inexplicable pulled them back to us. I didn't know what more I could do to adequately respond to the overwhelming outpouring of love and affection we were constantly being washed with, even though we were nobodies. I suppose this was their way of joining the Yatra, of touching something historic.

And even more crucially, this process of engagement with the people that the BJY forced on us began to break down barriers between the yatris. For the first time, we began to see that most of us share the same struggles, fears and aspirations. I remember observing a fellow yatri consciously avoiding eye contact with the teeming masses. He was not only struggling to connect with people, but was also clearly feeling excluded (since, by then, we were truly enjoying the spoken and unspoken conversations with